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Introduction to Management

MGNT110

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Power and Politics

Lecture 6



Learning Objectives

- Understand how power works in organisations
- Critically evaluate how decisions are REALLY made



What are Power and Politics?



What is Power?

- Power is the capacity of an individual or group to influence others and shape outcomes within an organisation.
- *Power is fundamental to organisations, as it enables action and coordination, much like oxygen enables breathing (Clegg et al., 2006)*

- The ability to make things happen
- or the ability to influence what happens

What is Politics?

- *Organisational politics is the practical domain of power in action, worked out through techniques of influence and various tactics (Buchanan & Badham, 1999).*
- Not just having power, but:
 - How people influence others
 - How they get what they want
 - How decisions are actually shaped behind the scenes

• Politics = **how power is USED**



• Politics = how power is USED

Power in action

- Power is not just theoretical
- It becomes real when people use it

Techniques of influence

- Ways people influence others
- Examples: Persuasion, Negotiation, Building relationships , Framing ideas

Tactics

- Politics can range from:
 - Positive: Collaboration, Networking, Persuasion
 - Negative: Manipulation, Withholding information, Backstabbing



“The fundamental concept in social science is power, in the same sense in which energy is the fundamental concept in physics” (Russell, 1938).

- In physics, everything depends on energy
- In organisations, everything depends on power



Power and negotiation

- Reward power
 - The holder has the opportunity to control resources and to give or withhold things wanted by others
- Coercive power
 - Exercised when a person compels others to behave in a certain way
- Legitimate power
 - The organization has invested power and authority in the position held
- Expert power
 - Vested in a person's knowledge, aptitude and ability- others are willing to defer to expertise
- Referent power
 - The holder is respected, admired, liked or personally identified with by others.

Name me an example for each of the above.

Given the power.
What about
respect?

Everyone Must
Work Extra
3 Hours

From today onwards, you all have to work
extra 3 hours after office hours.



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Forrest Trump



By Greg Perry

Challenger shuttle (1986)

SOURCES AND TYPES OF POWER



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xV25ol-NedQ>



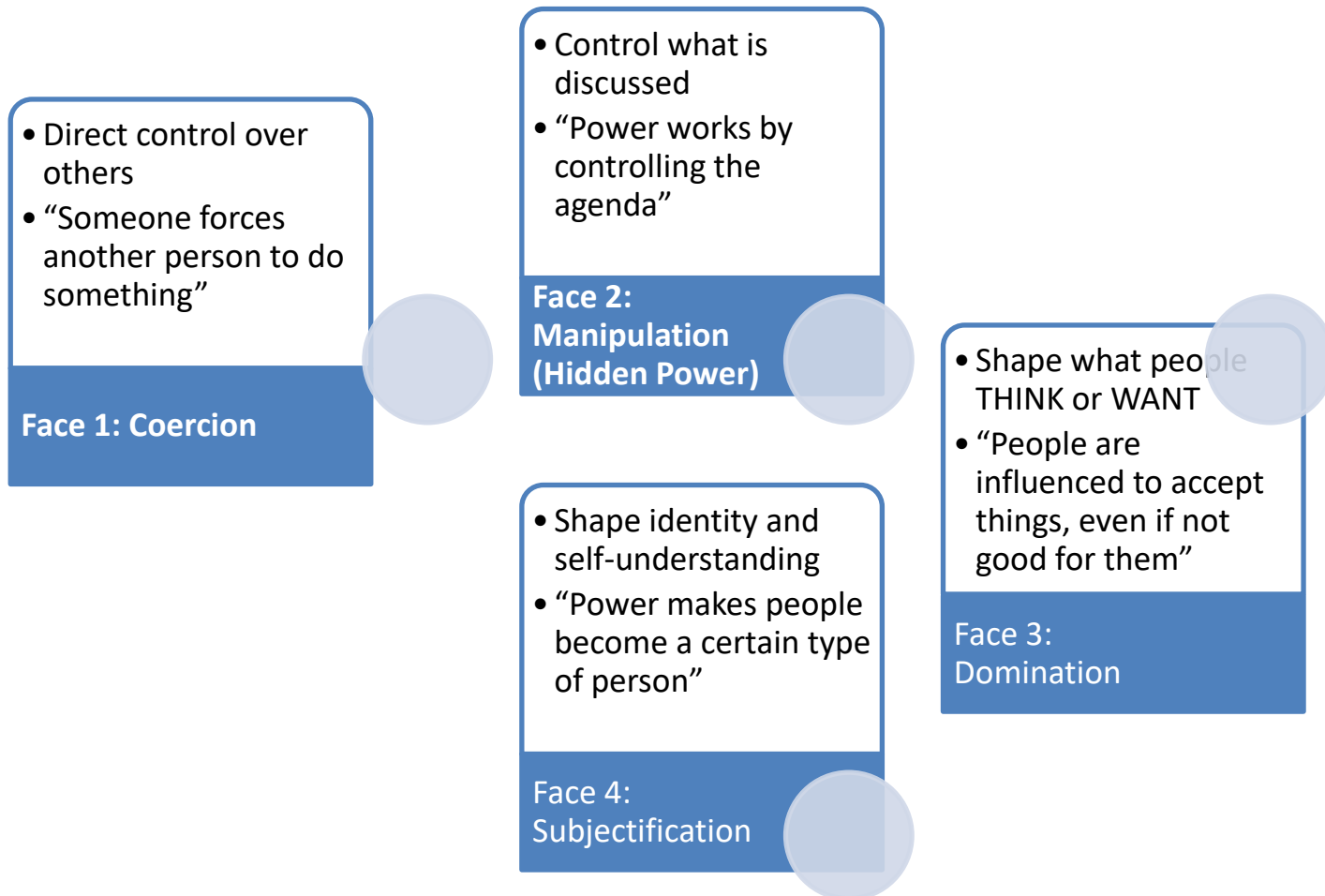
Summary

- NASA launched the Challenger shuttle (1986)
 - Engineers warned:
 - There was a serious technical issue (O-ring failure)
- Management:
 - Ignored warnings
 - Proceeded with launch
- Result: Explosion, loss of lives
- What this case shows
 - This is NOT just a technical failure
 - It is a power and politics failure
- Key Lesson Power can:
 - Distort decision-making
 - Silence important voices
 - Lead to serious consequences



Faces of power in organisations

Faces of power in organisations



(Fleming and Spicer, 2014).

- Workplace Conflict video



Face 1: Coercion (Robert Dahl, 1957)

- *“A has power over B to the extent that A can get B to do something that B would not otherwise do” (Dahl, 1957).*

Boss says:

“Stay late to finish this report”

- Employee doesn't want to
 - But still does it
 - That is coercive power



Face 2: Power as Manipulation (Bachrach & Baratz, 1962)

- Manipulation is the ability to shape decisions by controlling the agenda; what is included or excluded.

Instead of forcing people to do something...

- Power works by deciding:
 - What topics are discussed
 - What issues are ignored
 - If something is never discussed, it can never be challenged.



Face 3: Domination (Stephen Lukes)

- Domination is the ability to shape people's beliefs, preferences, and desires so they accept or support outcomes—even if those outcomes are not in their best interest.

Power is not just about:

- Forcing people (Face 1)
- Controlling agenda (Face 2)
- It is about shaping:
 - What people **think**
 - What people **want**



Face 4: Subjectification (Fleming & Spicer, 2014)

- Subjectification is the process by which power shapes individuals' identities, so they see themselves and behave in ways expected by the organisation.

Power does not just:

- Control behaviour (Face 1)
- Control discussion (Face 2)
- Shape beliefs (Face 3)

It goes further:

- It shapes who you are (your identity)



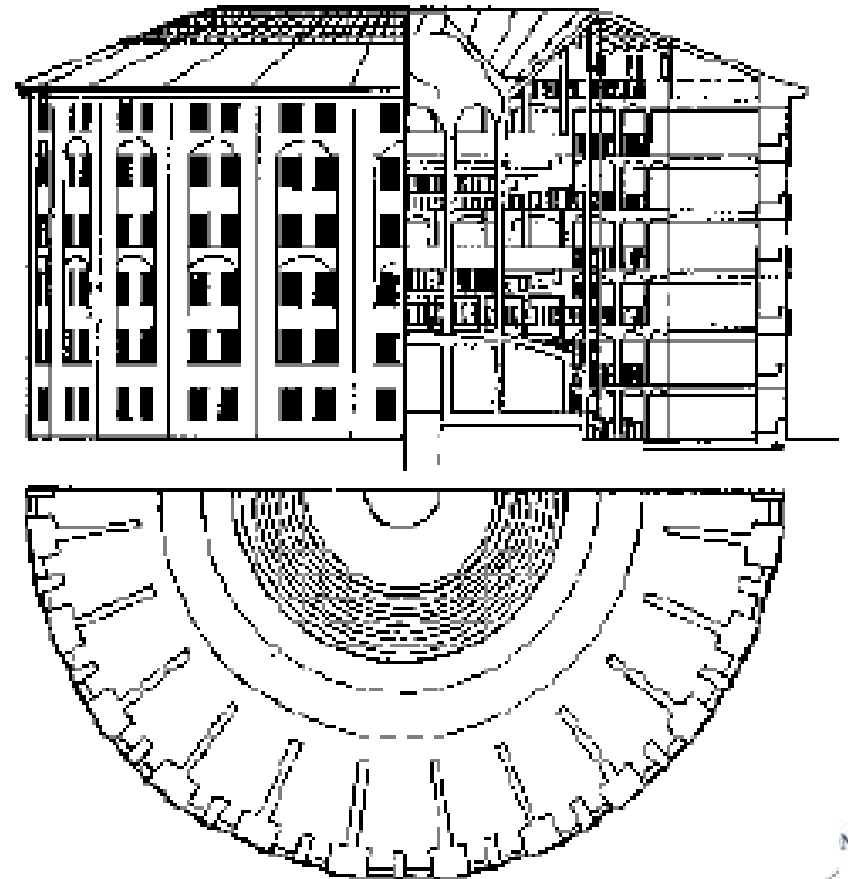
Break time

Back for more theories



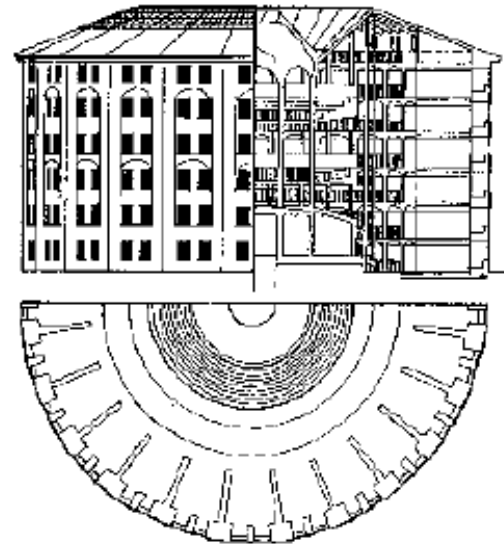
Bentham's Panopticon

- People behave because they might be watched at any moment, even if nobody is actually watching right then.
- because people cannot tell whether surveillance is active, they begin to regulate their own behaviour continuously.



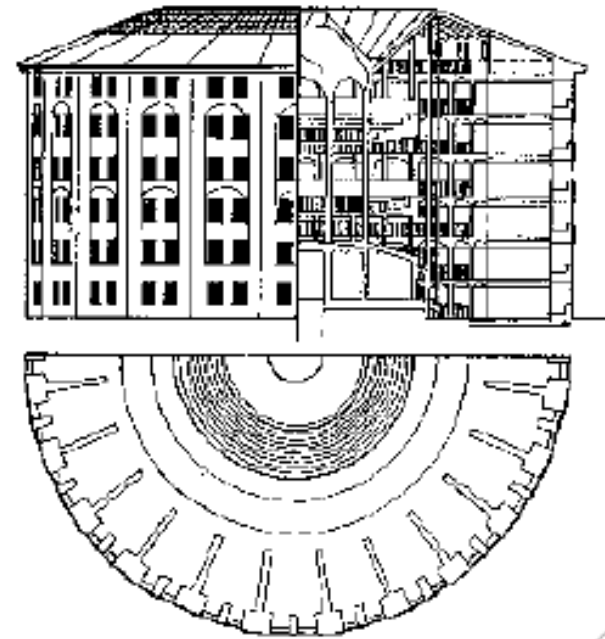
Power and “governmentality” (Foucault 1977)

- Power
 - Power can work “from inside the subject” rather than only from outside through direct commands.
- Governmentality
 - power does not only say, “Do this”
 - also shapes the environment, norms, language, performance systems, and knowledge in such a way that people start asking themselves, “What should I do to be a good employee?” or “How should I behave to fit in here?”
 - That is a deeper form of control because the person begins to govern themselves.



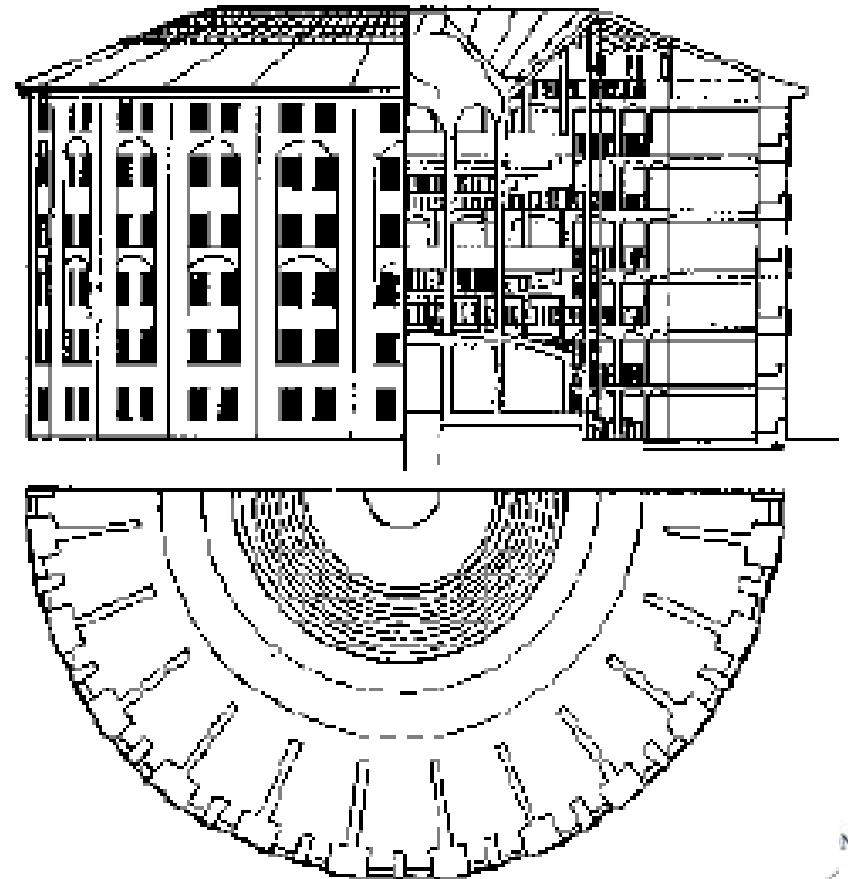
Power and “governmentality” (Foucault 1977)

- So if **Coercion** is “I obey because I am forced,” governmentality is closer to “I obey because I have come to see this behaviour as normal, expected, professional, responsible, or even desirable.”
- In management studies:
 - modern organisations often do not need harsh visible control all the time
 - They can get compliance through norms, metrics, culture, and self-surveillance.



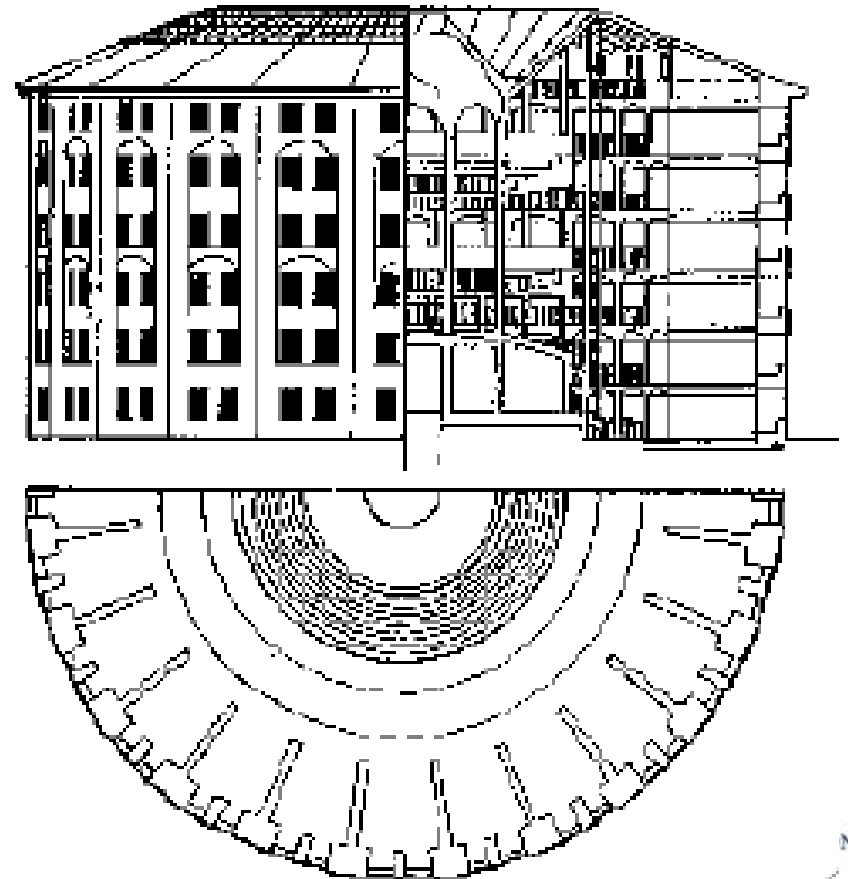
Bentham's Panopticon

- In an organisational setting:
 - productivity dashboards
 - KPI systems
 - attendance tracking
 - email monitoring
 - CCTV
 - call monitoring
 - team visibility tools
 - learning analytics
 - performance reviews



Bentham's Panopticon

- These systems create the feeling that one's behaviour is always visible, measurable, and comparable.
- As a result, people may work harder, speak more carefully, or hide uncertainty because they feel observed.



Soft Domination

- Domination does not always look aggressive, harsh, or authoritarian.
- It can appear polite, participative, empowering, and equal on the surface. Yet underneath, it still guides behaviour and limits autonomy.
 - Based on the appearance of equality in the organisation among peers
 - Electronic and team surveillance
 - in a project team, nobody may formally punish a member for leaving at 6 pm. But if everyone else stays until 9 pm, the person may feel disloyal or lazy. No manager has ordered them to stay. The team norm itself acts as power.
 - Empowerment



Concertive Control

- Another example of soft domination
 - The key idea is that control comes not mainly from a boss, but from the team itself.
 - A form of soft domination
 - Organisation is often more democratic and participative
 - Team is “self-managing”
- Note: the control is not absent. It is relocated. Instead of hierarchy directly controlling workers, the group internalises organisational values and then disciplines itself and each other.



Summary

- Power is the ability to influence others and shape outcomes (not just position)
- Politics is how power is used in practice
- Power can distort decisions (e.g., Challenger case) and silence important voices
- Modern power is often invisible and internalised (Foucault) “Soft domination” and “empowerment” can still be forms of control In teams, power shifts to peers (concertive control)



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